The End of Search? – How Gen Z is shifting from Google to Generative AI

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Abstract:

This study examines the shifting digital discovery habits of Generation Z (Gen Z), specifically focusing on the transition from traditional search engines like Google to Generative AI tools such as ChatGPT and Gemini. Using Information Foraging Theory and the Zero-Click search phenomenon as a framework, the research utilized a quantitative survey of 26 participants; the results are based on 17 verified Gen Z respondents who met the study's specific criteria. The survey focused on Gen Z "digital natives" to determine their usage frequency, behavioural factors, and trust in emerging technologies. The results indicate that while the older Gen Z respondents in this sample exploratory pilot study use AI for high-effort cognitive tasks—such as summarizing long texts (47.1%) and providing complex explanations (41.2%)—traditional search remains the dominant gateway to brand discovery. Google was the first choice for 64.7% of respondents when looking for new products. A significant "Trust Barrier" was identified within this sample, with 76.5% of participants having made no AI-driven purchases in the last 30 days. Furthermore, the study found a high level of "verification habit" among these participants (mean 4.12/5.0), where users feel compelled to verify AI claims via traditional links. The study concludes that among these older Gen Z respondents, AI offers superior speed, it currently lacks the authority and transparency required to replace traditional search engines in the consumer buying journey.

Keywords:

Generation Z, Gen Z, Generative AI, Search Engines, Google, Digital Discovery, Zero-Click Search, Information Foraging.

Contents

1 Introduction

The digital landscape is currently undergoing its most fundamental transformation since the invention of the World Wide Web. For over two decades, traditional keyword-based search engines have functioned as the primary gateway to information, serving as the central bridge between consumer intent and brand content. However, the emergence of Large Language Models (LLMs) and Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) is disrupting this long-standing habit. This shift is particularly observed among the specific demographic of older Gen Z respondents in this study, a demographic of digital natives who prioritize conversational interfaces and immediate, synthesized answers over the traditional list of hyperlinks. For international marketing, this evolution is not merely a technical update; it is a change in thinking that redefines how brands must maintain visibility in a global market. A hybrid era where AI-generated snapshots and conventional search results coexist has begun with the advent of Search Generative Experience (SGE). Users' "Information Foraging" Behavior is fundamentally changing as a result of this transition, which goes beyond simple interface changes. The integration of their models by Google and Microsoft means that algorithmic synthesis, not just indexing, is now necessary to ensure the visibility of global brands.

The study is motivated by the evolving role of traditional Search Engine Optimization (SEO). Historically, marketing success was measured by "ranking on page one". Today, however, the rise of tools like ChatGPT, Gemini, and Perplexity suggests that "discovery" is replacing "search". Industry forecasts from Gartner (2024) support this observation, predicting that traditional search engine volume will drop by 25% by 2026 as consumers increasingly pivot toward AI chatbots and virtual agents for information discovery. From an International Business perspective, it is critical to examine how this affects the global "findability" of brands or keywords. If consumers no longer click through to websites but instead receive a summary from an AI, the entire economic model of digital advertising and brand trust is put at risk. By placing this topic in a larger context, it becomes clear that it is not just about a new app, but about a new era of human-computer interaction in which the "gatekeeper" of information is changing.

1.1 Problem statement

There is a significant knowledge gap regarding the specific long-term effects of generative artificial intelligence (AI) on Gen Z's search behaviour, despite the technology's rapid global adoption. The core of this problematization lies in the fact that the rise of "Zero-Click Searches" in an AI-mediated environment has not yet been adequately explained by conventional marketing frameworks and scholarly literature. This shift represents a fundamental change in digital discovery that traditional business models have yet to fully address. There is a significant drop in traditional web traffic, according to recent research: in the US, only 374 out of 1,000 Google searches result in a click to the open web, while in the EU that number falls to 360 clicks (Fishkin, 2024). This indicates that users now complete almost 64% of searches without ever leaving the search engine(Fishkin, 2024). When a user's query is answered within the search interface or via an AI summary, there is no referral traffic to the original content creator's or brand's website. This is known as a "zero-click search" (Fishkin, 2024). The strategy of international business is seriously threatened by this change. Global businesses run the risk of suffering a measurable shift in brand recognition and digital findability if they continue investing large sums of money in traditional keyword-based Search Engine Optimization (SEO) while Gen Z, their target market, is turning to conversational "answer engines". Since the conventional "click-through" journey is being circumvented in an AI-first economy, the possible disruption of current digital marketing models makes this research pertinent.

Additionally, the shift raises important strategic and ethical issues related to algorithmic bias and the "Black Box" nature of LLMs. The objective is to investigate how information about foreign brands is filtered, as Gen Z increasingly relies on AI to recommend products. Market distortion and a decline in consumer trust may result from biased or inaccurate AI outputs. This study examines the survival of digital marketing tactics in a world where users no longer visit the source website, and the brand no longer controls the narrative.

1.2 Aim of the study

The purpose of this study is to shed light on how the older Gen Z respondents in this exploratory pilot study utilized generative AI tools compared to traditional search engines. More precisely, the following research questions are the focus of the study:

- To what extent is Gen Z utilizing AI-powered conversational agents for product discovery compared to traditional Google search?
- What elements—specifically speed, accuracy, and usability—are most influential in the uptake of these tools?
- How does Gen Z's trust in AI-generated brand recommendations compare to their trust in conventional sponsored search results?

1.3 Demarcation

The primary focus of this study is the older cohort of Gen Z. Although different organizations have different definitions for the precise birth years of this group—for example, the U.S. Census Bureau (U.S. Census Bureau, 2022) includes people born between 1997 and 2013 while the Pew Research Center (Pew Research Center, 2019) and Statistics Canada (Statistics Canada, 2021) define the bracket as 1997 to 2012; this study recognizes the broad 1997–2012 definition but specifically narrows its scope to respondents born between 1997 and 2002. The survey was disseminated within Arcada University of Applied Sciences, as well as among international student communities on Reddit and Discord, targeting this specific demographic. The study guaranteed access to "Global Digital Natives" who actively use English-language AI interfaces by focusing on these digital hubs. People in this range are currently starting or already established in the workforce, and they have the independent purchasing power required for a global study on consumer discovery, which is what drove this decision. Therefore, the study focuses on "digital natives," who were the first to incorporate generative AI into their college and early careers despite never having known a world without high-speed internet. This study does not include older cohorts such as Baby Boomers or Generation X because their search habits are typically more ingrained in conventional desktop-based keyword searching. It is important to note that, while the generation spans until 2012, the outcomes of this study focus on the "Older Gen Z" section, as the younger half of the generation was not included in the final sample. By focusing exclusively on this segment of Gen Z, the study can measure the “frontier” of behavioural change more precisely, as it will not be influenced by legacy digital habits. The study focuses on Gen Z consumers who use English-language interfaces for primary information discovery, also known as "Global Digital Natives". To maintain a distinct research focus, the technological scope is limited to text-based LLMs such as ChatGPT and Gemini, leaving out image-only or social-media discovery tools.

1.4 Definitions

- **Generative Engine Optimization (GEO):** An approach to ensure that digital content is appropriate for use by Large Language Models in their synthesized responses. (Aggarwal et al., 2024)
- **Zero-Click Search:** Zero-click search is an interaction in which the user's query is answered by the interface without sending them to any external websites. (Fishkin, 2024).
- **Information Foraging:** A model explaining how users navigate digital interfaces to find information with minimal effort. (Pirolli & Card, 1999).
- **Large Language Model (LLM):** An AI system that has been trained on massive datasets to comprehend, synthesize, and generate text responses that resemble those of a human. (OpenAI et al., 2023).

2 Theoretical Framework

The main theoretical framework used in this study to explain the cognitive reasons for altering search behaviours is Information Foraging Theory (IFT). While classic Information Foraging Theory (IFT) concentrated on browsing links, a recent study by (Klein-Avraham et al., 2026) shows that Generative AI has altered the “scent of information”. This shift is important to the study's findings because it explains why 47.1% of survey respondents now use AI for high-effort cognitive activities such as summarization, looking for the strongest 'information smell' with the lowest interaction cost. Users increasingly search for complex, risk-involved information using AI since it lowers the “interaction cost” compared to traditional search. The "zero-click" phenomenon has emerged as the dominating market reality (CLICKVISION, 2026). According to (Kuriatnyk, 2026), almost 60% of all searches now conclude without a click, increasing to 77% on mobile devices. This market shift requires Gen Z users to rely on generative engines' rapid summaries, while organic click-through rates drop by more than 60% when AI overviews are available (Kuriatnyk, 2026). Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) model, which provide market context and a strategic response, respectively, support IFT as the "main theory”. To address this, (Aggarwal et al., 2024) at Princeton University suggest the Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) framework, which serves as a strategic blueprint for brand visibility. Their findings show that citations, authoritative statements, and figures can increase a brand's visibility in AI responses by up to 40%. This is especially important for Gen Z, who emphasizes "accuracy perception" when determining whether to trust an AI-recommended brand (Aggarwal et al., 2024). This theoretical emphasis on accuracy is supported by the study's findings, which show a high 'Verification Habit' (mean score 4.12/5.0), confirming that, while speed is a motivator for AI use, accuracy remains a primary hurdle, leading to the hybrid behaviour of cross-referencing AI answers with traditional search results.

The purpose of this study is to see if and how older Gen Z “digital natives” use generative AI tools in their digital discovery process as compared to traditional search engines. Rather than assuming complete replacement of traditional platforms, this study looks at the unique scenarios in which Gen Z uses AI for high-effort research while still relying on conventional search for brand and product discovery. After reviewing earlier research on digital information seeking, this study introduces the three main models that make up the state-of-the-art framework for this study: information foraging, zero-click behaviours, and generative engine optimization (GEO). While Gen Z search behavior is expanding beyond linear models, the extent to which AI augments or replaces traditional search is highly influenced by user intent. Data from (Social Media Knowledge, 2025) shows that 34% of Gen Z now use AI chatbots for search—significantly higher than any other demographic. However, they use platforms based on intent: TikTok for trend discovery, AI for deep research, and Google only for specific utilitarian tasks.

2.1 Review of Previous Digital Discovery Research

Early research on digital discovery Jansen and Spink (2006) identified search engines as the key "gatekeepers" of the internet. Their research discovered a user behaviour pattern known as the "linear search" model, which was defined by simple keyword queries and a heavy reliance on the first page of search results. The "Ten Blue Links" offered by search engines such as Google were the unquestionable beginning point for consumer journeys during this time (Jansen & Spink, 2006). Users prioritized speed and direct navigation to external websites, according to these fundamental studies. However, when the digital landscape changes into the "Zero-Click" era (Fishkin, 2024), the emphasis shifted from finding connections to getting instant answers. This trend has culminated in the current shift toward generative AI tools among today's Gen Z population.

2.2 Core Theories and Models

The state-of-the-art in understanding current consumer discovery is represented by the models listed below. The empirical survey and the subsequent discussion of the findings are based on these theories.

2.2.1 Information Foraging Theory (IFT)

The concept remains the principal way to comprehend digital navigation that of Pirolli and Card (1999). Based on the "optimal foraging theory" of biology, their model proposes that users only follow the "information scent"—cues such as AI summaries or snippets—if the perceived benefit outweighs the effort needed to locate it. The user moves through this cycle of the AI-generated information gain according to the "Information scent", as shown in Figure 1. The Zero-Click phenomenon is used as a critical metric in this study to evaluate the transition from a 'click-through' economy to an 'answer' economy. By applying Fishkin’s (2024) data to the survey findings, this research investigates whether Gen Z’s reliance on instant AI answers creates a barrier to brand trust or if it successfully drives 'Zero-Click' commercial conversion.

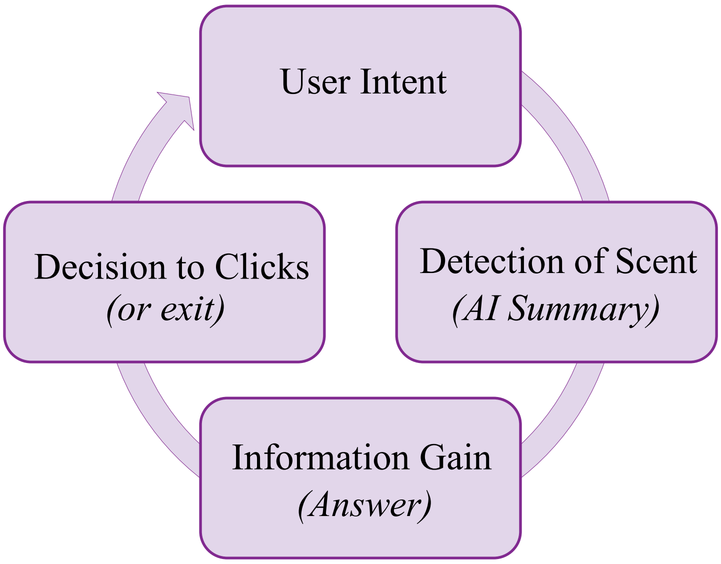

Figure 1. Information Foraging Cycle while using AI-driven discovery (Based on Pirolli & Card, 1999).

2.2.2 The Zero-Click Search Phenomenon

The Zero-Click phenomenon must be examined to understand the current state-of-the-art in search engines. The Zero-Click is used as a key statistic in this study to assess the shift from a "click-through" to a "answer" economy. By integrating Fishkin's (2024) data to survey results, this study analyzes if Gen Z's dependence on immediate AI replies poses a barrier to brand trust or if it effectively fosters 'Zero-Click' commercial conversion.

Industry studies have noted that search engines have evolved from "gateways" to "destinations," most notably by Fishkin (2024). Platforms lower the "cost" for the forager but remove the brand's traffic by offering answers right on the search page. The decline of the traditional open web in the US and EU markets is measured in this study using Fishkin (2024) metrics as a reference. The high percentage of zero-click searches in both the US and EU markets, as shown in Figure 2, indicates a shift in which the search engine becomes the user's ultimate destination rather than a gateway.

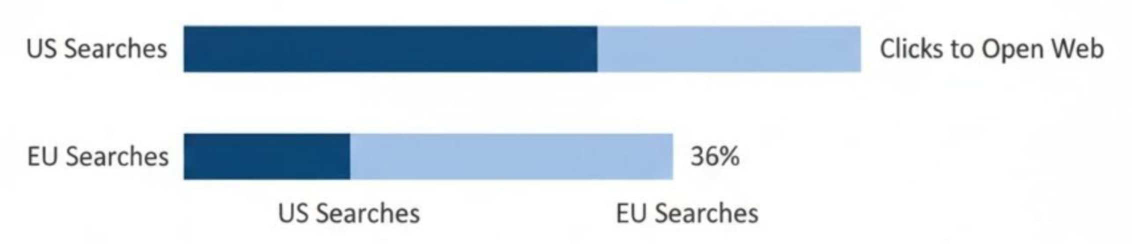

Figure 2. Zero-Click Search percentages in the US and EU markets (Source: Fishkin, 2024)

2.2.3 Generative Engine Optimization (GEO)

The new Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) model is a vital addition to conventional marketing theory. This methodology, created by (Aggarwal et al., 2024) emphasizes content synthesis above indexing. Since it provides the framework for how global companies should adjust their visibility tactics for Gen Z users who rely on AI summaries, this is an essential "level 3" concept for this thesis (Aggarwal et al., 2024). Figure 3's mapping of the optimization process illustrates the transition from simple indexing to content synthesis. The GEO framework provides a strategic correlation between AI search behavior and brand visibility. It is notably used in the Discussion to interpret the 'Verification Habit' score (4.12/5.0), implying that Gen Z's skepticism stems directly from the absence of authoritative citations and trust signals that the GEO model seeks to address.

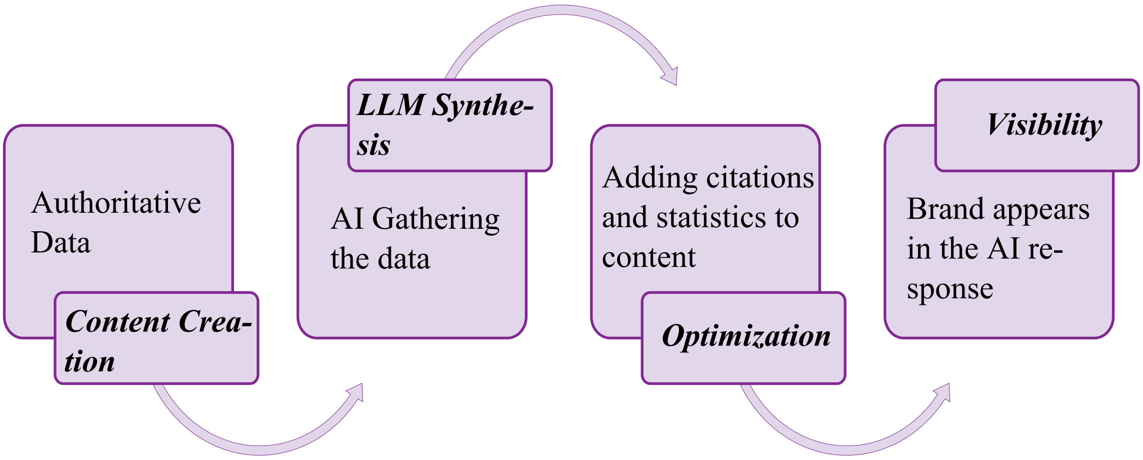

Figure 3. The Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) Framework: From Content Creation to AI Visibility. (Aggarwal et al., 2024)

2.3 Summary of the Theoretical Framework

GEO (the how), Zero-Click Searches (the what), and Information Foraging (the why) combine to form a thorough framework for this investigation. According to these theories, we are moving from a "Click-Economy" to an "Answer-Economy." By assessing the real behaviours and trust levels of Gen Z respondents, the empirical portion of this thesis tests these models.

3 Method

Establishing a strict framework for data collection is crucial as an introduction to the empirical phase of this study. In line with Saunders et al. (2023) the primary strategy used to accomplish study's goal and provide answers to the research questions is the selection of the research method. The methodical approach to data collection and analysis is referred to as a method. Selecting the appropriate approach is crucial because it ensures that the data acquired are pertinent to the problem statement and can provide a reliable response to the research questions (Saunders et al., 2023). This study's methodology align with the objective of examining Gen Z's shift from conventional search to AI-mediated discovery.

3.1 Choice of method

This study utilized a structured digital survey as a quantitative research method, specifically designed as an exploratory pilot study. To explain phenomena or spot trends in a population, quantitative research collects numerical data (Saunders et al., 2023). This approach is appropriate for this research since it makes it possible to gather standardized data from a specific demographic of Gen Z consumers to identify preliminary patters. While the sample size (n=17) does not allow for broad statistical generalization, the survey's quantitative nature allows it to measure variables such as trust and frequency of use that would be difficult to measure using qualitative interviews alone, as well as identify initial behavioral trends in the "Answer-Economy". By framing the procedure as an experimental pilot, the study focuses on the "frontier" of behavior among high-intent digital natives, creating a quantifiable baseline for future, larger-scale investigations.

3.2 Respondents

Selecting the right respondents is essential to making sure the study includes the target population. Research indicates that for a study to be considered representative of its specific scope, participants must be chosen according to certain standards that correspond with the research boundaries (Saunders et al., 2023). Respondents to this study are "Global Digital Natives" representing the older cohort of Gen Z who were born between 1997 and 2002. Students and young professionals from other countries who use English-language interfaces are the target audience for a purposive convenience sampling technique. The table below explains the filtering method used to verify the integrity of the exploratory pilot sample:

Table 1. Respondent Selection Criteria and Target Sample Demographics.

Selection Criterion	Requirement for Inclusion	Actual Sample Result
Birth Year (Gen Z)	Born between 1997 and 2012	**1997–2002** (Older Gen Z)
Interface Language	English-language interface users	Global Digital Natives
AI Tool Usage	Active users of ChatGPT, Gemini, etc.	Verified active users
Data Integrity	Completed all behavioural sections	26 total responses collected
Final Sample (n)	Must meet all above criteria	17 verified respondents

3.3 Survey

A survey is a research method that makes it possible to gather information from a sizable population in a very cost-effective manner (Saunders et al., 2023). A well-designed survey must be structured to guarantee that each question directly contributes to answering the research questions while reducing respondent bias, according to methodology literature. To go beyond binary data and capture the intensity of respondent behaviour as well as their levels of trust and purchase intent, the survey for this study was created using 5-point Likert scales. Every question has a corresponding theoretical framework. For example, questions about platform frequency and "Zero-Click" behaviour are related to Information Foraging Theory, while new questions about source verification and brand recommendations deal with the shift to an "Answer Economy." Two open-ended questions were included to see the qualitative reasoning behind the platform choices made by the participants to provide deeper context.

The survey was refined after a pilot review to ensure neutral phrasing and to capture actual purchase behaviour rather than just user attitudes. The questionnaire was made digitally using the Tally survey platform, which allowed for a clean user interface and reliable, anonymous data collection. Following ethical guidelines, the survey begins with a formal disclosure outlining the study's purpose, the researcher's identity, and a statement of informed consent (see Appendix 2), ensuring all data is processed anonymously. The full survey guide is available in Appendix 1.

3.4 Research approach

The study's logic and practical application are defined by the research approach. This study employs a deductive methodology, developing research questions based on accepted theory and evaluating them with empirical data. The study is conducted digitally via an anonymous online survey link generated through the Tally platform. Targeting professional platforms such as Discord, Reddit, and international student networks, participation was entirely voluntary. Over the course of one week, data was collected. Before being exported for analysis, responses are digitally recorded and documented within the secure database of the survey platform.

3.5 Analysis of the data

The raw dataset (n=26) underwent a thorough data cleaning procedure to guarantee the validity of the results. The final analysis only included respondents born between 1997 and 2002 who gave their express consent, yielding a final sample size of (n=17). Excel was used for quantitative analysis, and 16 different metrics were computed to answer the research questions, such as means for frequency and percentages for task-specific preferences. The data was analyzed using a structured, four-step approach in Microsoft Excel to ensure each research question was addressed:

1. **Data Cleaning and Filtering:** To exclude respondents who fall outside the Gen Z birth-year range (1997–2012), the raw data from Tally was filtered. This ensured the "digital native" sample's demographic integrity.

2. **Quantitative Analysis (RQ1 & RQ3):** Mean scores for platform frequency and trust levels were calculated using descriptive statistics. The primary discovery gateway for RQ1 was identified by frequency distributions. The trust gap was identified for RQ3 by comparing the mean "trust scores" for AI recommendations directly to the mean scores for traditional sponsored ads.
3. **Theoretical Mapping (RQ2):** Information Foraging Theory was employed to analyze behavioural drivers, such as speed, relevance, and UI. The Mean scores were used to identify the "information scent" of AI summaries. The theory explains user hesitation by interpreting a high mean score in the "verification habit" as a high interaction cost.
4. **Supplementary qualitative of open-ended responses:** "Source Transparency" and "Accuracy" were the recurring themes that were used to categorize open-ended responses regarding trust. These topics were used to provide context for numerical trust scores.

3.6 Use of AI

In accordance with academic integrity guidelines, this section provides a transparent description of how generative AI tools were utilized in the development of this thesis.

Tools and Stages of Use

Generative AI tools, specifically Gemini, was used during the drafting and finalization stages of the manuscript. These tools were primarily designed to give language help and structural organization.

Scope of Assistance

AI was utilized for the following specific tasks:

- **Language Support:** Improving English-language phrase to maintain academic clarity and grammatical accuracy.
- **Structural Organization:** Assisting with the logical flow and transition of complicated theoretical frameworks like Information Foraging Theory and GEO.
- **Summarizing and editing:** Include condensing industry benchmarks and refining draft content to ensure brevity and professionalism.

Human Oversight and Accountability

The researcher retained complete creative and analytical control over the final paper through the following verification processes:

- **Manual Review:** The researcher manually reviewed, modified, and rewrote each AI-supported recommendation to ensure that it appropriately reflected the study's unique context.
- **Accuracy Checks:** All citations and references were carefully checked against original sources to confirm their authenticity and avoid errors.
- **Data Integrity:** All main survey findings were independently evaluated in Microsoft Excel before being incorporated into the text. The author's original intellectual contributions include his interpretations and conclusions based on this data.

The final draft, including the analysis and findings, is the sole responsibility of the researcher.

3.7 Validity and reliability

According to Saunders et al. (2023), **validity** refers to the extent to which a data collection method accurately measures what it was intended to measure, while **reliability** refers to the consistency of the findings and the ability for the research to be replicated by others. To ensure the validity of this study, a pilot test was conducted with three students to assess whether the questions were clear and effectively aligned with the research goals. Following the principles of construct validity, each survey question was designed to directly address a specific research question. Reliability was ensured through standardized 5-point Likert scales, which allowed for a consistent and replicable measurement of participant attitudes across different platforms. By employing a structured workbook approach, data validity was preserved throughout the analysis. To prevent the unintentional inclusion of excluded responses, all computations were performed on a separate sheet of cleaned data, distinct from the raw data. A clear chain of evidence from the survey's raw data input into the final statistical results was established through this organized flow.

3.8 Research ethics

The "Good scientific practice at Arcada University of Applied Sciences" principles are followed in this study. An introductory statement in the survey informs each participant of the study's purpose, and prior to participation, informed consent is required. Participation is completely anonymous; no IP addresses or personal identifiers are kept. All responses are reviewed collectively in order to maintain the respondents' total confidentiality.

4 Results

The quantitative survey results are presented and analyzed in this chapter. The purpose of the survey was to compare traditional search engines like Google with generative AI tools to better understand how Gen Z is changing their search habits. The study involved 26 respondents in total. The findings are presented impartially, emphasizing task-specific preferences, usage frequency, and demographic profiles.

4.1 Demographic Profile and Data Integrity

The study, which aimed to target Gen Z, successfully identified 17 eligible individuals born between 1997 and 2002 out of a total of 26 however, age-demographic mismatches (specifically respondents born between 2003 and 2012, or before 1997) resulted in the exclusion of 34.6% of the raw responses during the cleaning phase. In order to maintain a "pure" sample of older digital natives and guarantee that the study appropriately represents the digital habits of the target demographic, this filtration procedure was required. Most participants were born in 2001 and 2002, and they are a "digitally native" group in their early twenties. The significance of this life stage lies in its significance as it marks the peak of the "Gen Z" impact on digital commerce trends. Prior to analysis, the data integrity was ensured by removing respondents who were not part of the verified 1997-2002 birth range or who did not complete the behavioural sections.

4.2 Utilization and Discovery Habits (RQ1)

The data shows that although generative AI is used in daily routines of the respondents, traditional search engines remain the primary means of navigating the internet for the respondents.

- **Frequency of Use:** The frequency of use of traditional search engines (Google/Bing) was rated on a scale of 1 to 5, with a mean score of 4.71, which indicates a consistent level of daily reliance. On the other hand, the mean score for Generative AI tools (ChatGPT/Gemini) was 2.35.
- **The "First Click" Habit:** 64.7% of respondents visited Google first when looking for a new product or brand. Generative AI and social media platforms accounted for an equal percentage of the remaining discovery traffic, with 11.8% of respondents choosing each as their major gateway.

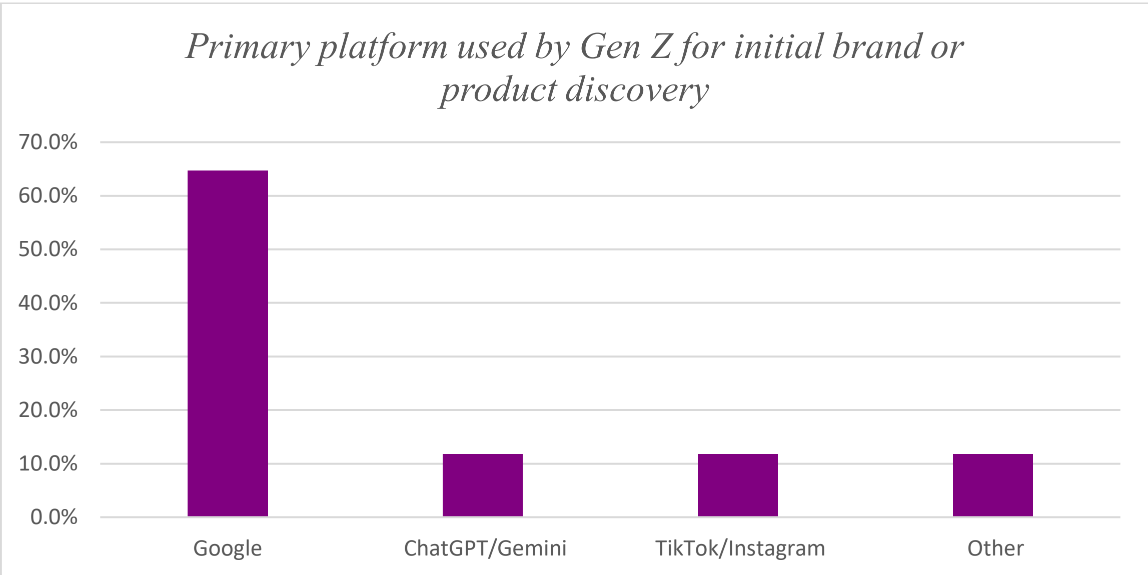

Figure 4: Primary platform used by Gen Z for initial brand or product discovery)

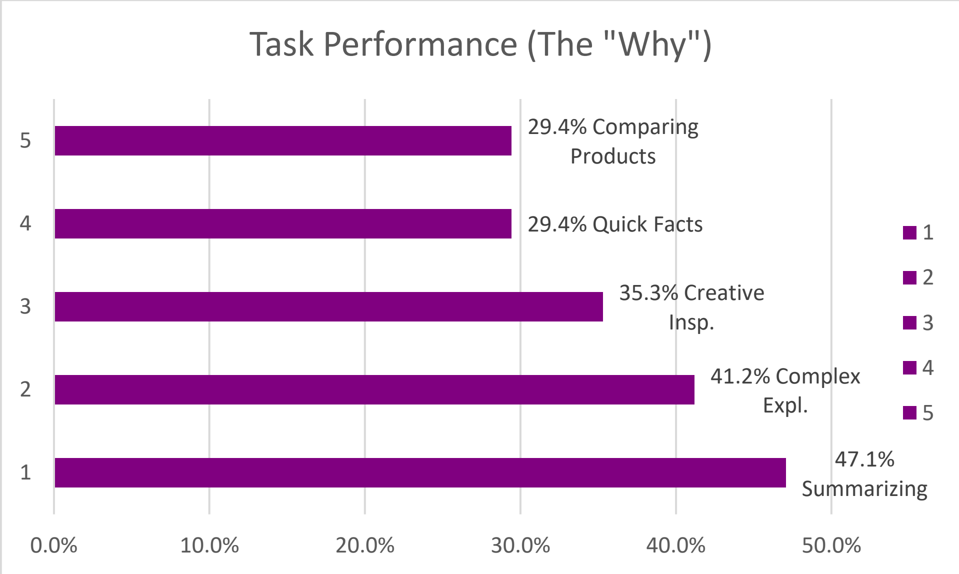

Figure 5: User preference for Generative AI over traditional search based on task type.

Buying Journey: Respondents in this study explicitly stated that they do not use AI to make buying decisions (64.7%). Reported interaction within this specific sample is restricted to the upper part of the sales funnel, specifically focusing on "comparing specific models/prices" (35.3%) and "initial idea gathering" (29.4%).

4.3 Behavioural Drivers (RQ2)

Several behavioural drivers were measured to compare platform preferences.

- **Speed vs. Accuracy:** The metric in which AI performed better than the neutral midpoint was speed (3.41). The scores for UI (2.18) and relevance (2.18) favoured traditional search engines.

Table 2. User preference for Generative AI over traditional search based on task type. (Scores >3 favour AI, <3 favour Traditional Search)

Metric	Mean Score (1–5)
Speed of obtaining information	3.41
Relevance of information	2.18
User Interface (UI) Preference	2.18
Zero-Click Influence	2.12

- **Contextual Preference:** Respondents utilized AI for tasks involving text elaboration (47.1%) and intricate explanations (41.2%). Google remains the preferred choice for “Quick Facts” (29.4%).

4.4 Trust, Scepticism, and Verification (RQ3)

The survey measured levels of trust and verification habits among respondents.

- **The Verification Habit:** Information Verification had the highest single mean score in the study (4.12/5.0). The majority of respondents indicated that they frequently or consistently click on source links to verify the information provided by an AI.
- **Trust in Recommendations:** The trust score for brand recommendations produced by AI was (2.41/5.0).
- **Actual Purchase Conversion:** In the last 30 days, 76.5% of respondents said they had not made any purchases after making the initial discovery utilizing an AI tool. This demonstrates that the bulk of the "Older Gen Z" sample still relies on traditional channels for final financial transactions.

4.5 Qualitative Review of Open-Ended Responses

In the survey's last portion, respondents offered qualitative comments on the criteria that would boost their trust in AI-generated brand suggestions. A qualitative analysis of these open-ended replies (detailed in Appendix 3) demonstrated that Older Gen Z values dependable information and transparency over conversational fluency.

The review established three key drivers of trust, illustrated by examples from participant feedback:

- **Direct Citations:** Respondents expressed a fundamental need to see the origin of data, with one participant noting, **"I need to see exactly where the information came from"**.

- **Accuracy over Fluency:** Factual correctness is valued over "human-like" tone; as one respondent stated, **"It's more important to me that it be correct than that it sound human"**.
- **Human Experience:** Participants believe AI lacks authenticity in certain areas, suggesting that **"AI cannot replace human-made reviews and real-world testing"**.

5 Discussion

The following chapter combines the empirical data reported in the preceding section with the theoretical frameworks developed in the literature study. Interpreting the data's "Generation Z paradox"—the strong technical dependence on AI for information processing and the poor commercial faith in AI for brand discovery—is the main goal. This debate demonstrates how the transition to Generative AI is reorganizing the digital customer journey and what these behavioural shifts signify for future marketing tactics by bridging the gap between raw statistical data and the larger marketing context.

5.1 Discussion of results

The study's findings indicate that although the participants in this sample are spearheading the shift to "Answer-Engine" consumption, they are still dependent on conventional search infrastructures when making important decisions. According to the research, 41.2% of respondents use AI for sophisticated explanations, while 47.1% use it for text summaries. This shows that artificial intelligence is now the key tool for cognitive offloading; Gen Z assigned the initial phase of research to a Large Language Model (LLM) rather than manually combining data from several websites. Since AI reduces the "interaction cost" of finding information, this behaviour is consistent with Information Foraging Theory (Pirolli & Card, 1999).

However, the results reveal a notable "Efficiency Gap" among these participants where AI wins on speed but loses on perceived reliability. The 64.7% preference for Google in product research reveals a sizable "Trust Gap". AI is not yet regarded as a commercial authority, even though its data processing capabilities are trusted and notably AI wins on speed but loses on experience. This suggests that Google's fundamental usefulness is now being sustained by its perceived authority, but AI is competing with social platforms for first discovery rather than replacing the major search gateway. AI is not yet acknowledged as a business authority, and it excels at speed (3.41) but falls short on user experience (2.18).

The most significant finding of this study is the "Trust Barrier", which resulted in a stagnation of the buying journey within AI interfaces. The group's high "Verification Habit" mean score of 4.12/5.0 demonstrated that they were aware of the risks associated with AI "hallucinations”. This high level of scepticism reinforces the need for Aggarwal et al. (2024) Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) paradigm, which underlines that for a brand to be trusted in an AI environment, authoritative statements and direct citations should be prioritized. The poll results suggest that these Older Gen Z respondents actively seeks for these trust cues, thereby changing the intended 'Zero-Click' tool into a 'Multi-Click' process when transparency is absent. They have developed a hybrid strategy that makes advantage of AI to gain a fundamental understanding before going back to traditional search engines to confirm facts and brand authenticity (Jansen & Spink, 2006). This reveals that, while AI is a great research helper for high-effort cognitive activities, it lacks the ability to drive true financial conversion or serve as an unbiased curator in the eyes of Older Gen Z. For marketers, this means that search engines are still winning the war for validation even as AI is winning the war for knowledge.

5.2 Discussion of method

This study's technique was designed to ensure a high level of "internal validity" by rigorously screening the participant pool. The decision to reject 34.6% of responses to focus only on 17 certified Gen Z "digital natives" was essential to maintaining the integrity of the study questions, even though the initial survey included 26 respondents. This is like the stringent method recommended by Saunders et al. (2023) to ensure that the sample fairly represents the intended population.

To guarantee transparency, a properly structured "audit trail" was kept throughout the analysis. An accompanying Excel spreadsheet supports the empirical findings of this study; in particular, each figure that presents primary data (Figures 4 and 5) includes a corresponding active formula and data column, enabling complete replicability of the results. Secondary statistics are used as a baseline for market context and are credited to their original source. One example of this is the industry metrics from (Fishkin, 2024) seen in Figure 2. >

Nonetheless, the method's reliance on self-reported data is a notable limitation. Participants in digital behaviour studies may inflate their "verification habits" to look more tech-savvy (4.12). Nevertheless, given the agreement between the quantitative scores and the qualitative open-ended responses about "source transparency," the results are a reliable depiction of current Gen Z attitudes.

6 Conclusion

The goal of this study was to investigate how Generation Z consumers use generative AI as a discovery tool vs standard search engines. While the intended research goal was to cover the whole Generation Z demographic (1997-2012), the resulting data represents a selective pilot study on "Older Gen Z" (born 1997-2002). Based on the findings and subsequent discussion of this particular cohort, the following conclusions are formed in direct answer to the study questions:

RQ1: How is generative AI currently being used as a discovery tool by Older Gen Z?

The study indicates that, while AI has been integrated into the digital habits of these older Gen Z respondents, it serves as a supplement rather than a replacement for traditional search methods. Respondents primarily utilize AI for high-effort cognitive tasks, such as summarizing complex information (47.1%) and explaining intricate topics (41.2%). Traditional search engines continue to be the most popular for brand and product discovery, with 64.7% of participants choosing Google as their "first-click" destination.

RQ2: What are the primary behavioural drivers that influence the choice between AI and traditional search?

The primary driver of AI adoption is "Speed," which was the only performance indicator where AI scored higher than the neutral middle point (3.41). Traditional search engines, on the other hand, are chosen for their superior user interface and relevancy, both of which received a score of 2.18, indicating a preference for the established search engine layout over modern AI interfaces. The platform choice is contextual: AI is picked for "cognitive offloading" and text-based elaboration, while conventional search remains the preferred choice for "Quick Facts" (29.4%).

RQ3: To what extent does trust and information verification affect the transition to AI-led discovery?

Trust remains the most significant barrier to the adoption of AI-led discovery for this sample. The study identified a profound "Trust Gap," with brand recommendations from AI receiving a low trust score of 2.41. This lack of confidence is reflected in a strong "Verification Habit" (mean score of 4.12), with 82.4% of respondents feeling the need to regularly or always check AI-generated assertions via external connections. As a result, while AI helps with research, it does not yet generate cash conversion; 76.5% of respondents had not made a purchase motivated by AI discovery in the last 30 days.

Summary

To summarize, for Older Gen Z respondents in this exploratory pilot study, AI is a tool for information processing rather than a major gateway for business transactions. The move to "Zero-Click" commerce is now stymied by a basic requirement for source transparency and human-validated reviews, which traditional search engines are thought to deliver more consistently.

6.1 Limitations of the study

To present a fair assessment of the empirical results, several limitations must be recognized. The sample size (n=17) is the primary limitation. While the data was carefully filtered to ensure it accurately reflected the "Digital Native" population, the findings are limited to the older portion of Gen Z (1997-2002). This indicates that the study does not cover the whole 1997-2012 generational period specified in the demarcation, as the younger half of the cohort is absent from the data. The results should be taken as an exploratory pilot study rather than a final generalization of the entire Gen Z population.

Additionally, the study was carried out at a time when technology was extremely unstable. With major firms like OpenAI and Google releasing weekly updates to its search integrations, the "state-of-the-art" (Jansen & Spink, 2006) is developing faster than academic publishing. This indicates that respondents' opinions of "Trust" and "UI Preference" are dependent on a particular point in time and could change as AI tools become less "novel" and more integrated. Last but not least, the study lacks the in-depth qualitative "why" that could be obtained through one-on-one interviews due to its reliance on a computerized poll, which leaves some of the psychological aspects that underlie the "Trust Barrier" subject to interpretation.

6.2 Suggestions for further studies

Future studies should use a longitudinal approach to monitor how trust in AI changes over a 12- to 24-month period, given the recent findings of the "Verification Loop." It will be interesting to see whether the "Verification Habit" (now 4.12/5.0) declines or whether scepticism remains a persistent characteristic of Gen Z users as AI models incorporate more reliable citations and real-time web access.

A comparative generational analysis is another interesting direction for future research. It would be possible to determine if the shift toward AI-driven discovery represents a universal change in human information foraging or if it is a distinctive behavioural marker of individuals who grew up in the "Zero-Click" age by testing these same study questions against Millennials or Gen X. Lastly, eye-tracking or heat-map technologies could let future researchers quantify "Information Scent" more objectively than self-reported surveys by comparing actual interaction costs between an AI Chat interface and a Google Search Results Page.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Interview Guide (Survey Questionnaire)

Note: All participants were first presented with the ethical disclosure and consent form (see Appendix 2) before answering the following questions.

Part 1: Demographics & Frequency (Supporting RQ1)

1. **Year of Birth:** (Open entry to verify 1997–2012 range).
2. **On a scale of 1–5, how often do you use traditional search engines (Google/Bing) for daily information seeking?** (1: Never, 5: Multiple times daily).
3. **On a scale of 1–5, how often do you use Generative AI (ChatGPT/Gemini/Perplexity) for daily information seeking?** (Scale: 1: Never, 5: Multiple times daily).
4. **When you are looking for a new product or brand, which platform do you typically visit FIRST?** (Options: Google, TikTok/Instagram, ChatGPT/Gemini, Other).
5. **In what specific situations do you prefer AI over Google?** (Checkboxes: Quick facts, comparing products, creative inspiration, complex explanations, summarizing long text).
6. **When using AI for product discovery, how much of the 'buying journey' do you complete within the AI interface before switching to a traditional site?).** (Options: Only initial idea gathering; Comparing specific models/prices; Final decision making; I do not use AI for buying decisions).

Part 2: Behavioural Drivers (Supporting RQ2)

7. **How would you compare the speed of obtaining information through AI versus traditional search engines?** (Scale: 1: AI is much slower, 5: AI is much faster).
8. **Compare the relevance of information provided by AI summaries to the results provided by a list of website links.** (Scale 1: Website links are more relevant, 5: AI summaries are more relevant).

9. **Rate your preference regarding the user interface of these platforms.** (Scale 1: Strongly prefer Search Engine Results Pages, 5: Strongly prefer AI Chat interfaces).
10. **How much does the "Zero-Click" nature of AI (getting the answer without visiting a website) influence your choice to use it?** (Scale 1–5: Not at all to Highly Influential).

Part 3: Trust & Purchase Influence (Supporting RQ3)

11. **I trust the accuracy of a brand recommendation from an AI more than a sponsored 'Ad' on Google.** (Scale 1–5).
12. **I feel confident making a purchase decision based solely on information provided by an AI summary.** (Scale 1–5).
13. **How often do you verify the information provided by an AI by clicking on the source links?** (1: Never, 5: Always).
14. **How often have you relied solely on an AI-generated recommendation to finalize a purchase without visiting the brand's official website?** (Scale 1: Never, 5: Always).
15. **Open Question: What would make you trust an AI's brand recommendation more? (e.g., seeing sources, clearer language, brand reputation).**
16. **In the past 30 days, have you made a physical or digital purchase where the initial discovery of the product happened through a Generative AI tool (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini)?** (Options: Yes, once; Yes, multiple times; No; I used AI for research but bought a product I already knew).

Closing Message:

"Thank you for your response! Your feedback is incredibly valuable for this research on AI-driven consumer discovery."

Appendix 2: Consent and Distribution

The following ethical disclosure was presented to and accepted by all participants prior to data collection:

International Study on AI-Driven Consumer Discovery

Markus Pulkkinen is conducting this study for his international business bachelor's thesis at Arcada University of Applied Sciences. This study aims to understand the use of generative AI by Generation Z (e.g., Gemini, ChatGPT) compared to conventional search engines. Participation is completely voluntary, and you are free to stop at any time. All information gathered is completely anonymous; no personal identifiers or IP addresses will be saved. The results will be examined and categorized for academic purposes only. By continuing with this survey, you provide your informed consent to participate and acknowledge that your responses will be processed anonymously.

The survey was disseminated within Arcada University of Applied Sciences, as well as among international student communities on Reddit and Discord, to engage the target demographic. These digital platforms were selected to ensure a broad geographical reach and to capture the perspectives of 'digital natives' across different educational and social environments. To maintain academic integrity, recruitment was conducted through public forums and student-specific channels where the research goals were clearly stated to potential participants.

Appendix 3: Qualitative review of open-ended responses

The following qualitative review of open-ended responses was conducted on the qualitative data gathered from the open-ended question: "What would make you trust an AI’s brand recommendation more?". Recurring sentiments were categorized into three primary themes that explain the current "Trust Gap" in older Gen Z consumer behaviour.

Theme	**Core Sentiment**	**Illustrative Participant Quote / Sentiment**
Source Transparency	A critical need for direct links and citations to verify AI claims.	"I need to see exactly where the information came from".
Accuracy over Fluency	A preference for factual correctness over "human-like" conversational language.	" It's more important to me that it be correct than that it sound human".
Human Validation	The belief that AI cannot replicate real-world testing or personal experiences.	"AI cannot replace human-made reviews and real-world testing".

Appendix 4: Survey Data Visualizations (Reference)

This appendix includes contextual information for the data visualizations used in this study. To establish a clear and consistent numbering scheme, all important charts and graphs were integrated directly into the thesis' main body.

The visual representations of the survey data can be found in the following sections:

- **Primary Discovery Platforms:** See Figure 4 in Section 4.2.
- **AI vs. Traditional Search (Speed/UI/Relevance):** See Figure 5 in Section 4.2.
- **The "Verification Habit" Mean Scores:** See Table 2 in Section 4.3.

Note on Data Source: The above visualizations were created using the raw response data from the n=17 sample of Older Gen Z customers, as explained in the Methodology (Section 3.2). The entire set of survey questions used to obtain these data may be seen in Appendix 1.